

WHAT IS REALITY?

Get real! The answer to this question seems obvious. Things that exist—that is, have physical shape or being—are real, while anything that is made up or imaginary is not real. But it is not quite as simple as that. Philosophers have argued for centuries over the nature of reality. That is because the question they are most concerned with asking—and trying to answer—is how do we know what is real; in other words, how do we distinguish between what is real and what is not? Let's go for a reality check . . .

AM I REAL?

Pinch yourself—you felt that, didn't you? You know you are real because you have sensory perception—sight, hearing, touch, smell, and taste. You walk, talk, and move around. More importantly, you are aware that you have a mind and being of your own. A great French philosopher, René Descartes (1596–1650), stated that because he had a brain, he could be sure of his own existence. He summed this up in the statement, “I think, therefore I am.”

SO, ARE

OTHER PEOPLE REAL?

Other people walk, talk, and move around, like you do. So do robots, but the difference is that robots cannot think for themselves and their batteries run down. Though they are real things, they are not real like us. However, you can tell from the way other people behave that they have brains, think for themselves, and are as real as you are.

